on a monolith; and beyond, at Topra in Haryana (also subsequently transported to Delhi by the same sultan), another pillar with the same message was erected. The Topra pillar was singular because it had an additional rescript, a seventh edict that has not been found in its entirety anywhere else. A short Aramaic inscription at Kandahar was drafted in a way suggesting that the engravers were aware of the seventh pillar edict, but, unlike at Topra, it is not there part of a set. Beyond North India is an inscribed sandstone slab (cut from a pillar), apparently from the Amaravati stupa site in the lower Krishna valley of Andhra. However, the few lines that have survived suggest that its language and terminology were similar to rock edicts rather than the expansive message put on pillars.[1] It is entirely possible that the edicts were put up elsewhere too, for inscribed pillars with messages purportedly by Ashoka were described centuries later by Chinese pilgrims. However, they have since disappeared.

The pillars carry practically identical messages. As with the rock edicts earlier, they seem consciously compiled into a kind of anthology. They include a record of various past Ashokan actions and initiatives and so have been described as ‘a compilation of originally independent, isolated documents.’[2] Ashoka himself makes this evident by specifying the points in time at which particular policies had been initiated or implemented, the bulk having been in the twenty-sixth year of his anointment. The edicts could only have been disseminated as a connected group after that crucial year, the single exception being Topra, where the seventh edict was written in the twenty-seventh year.

The imprint of age and experience can be seen in the emperor’s words as, for instance, in the very different way in which they were set down. The edicts that formed Ashoka’s fourteen major rock epigraphs had, as we saw, been issued over some four years. When the emperor decided to carve them on rock they had, in several instances, been dispatched in batches. The six pillar edicts were not staggered, being all engraved like a single prearranged